

As I reflect on where I am now in my counseling journey, my perspective has changed significantly from when I first studied counseling ethics. At that time, I was focused on learning the ACA Code of Ethics and understanding how ethical principles would guide my future work as a professional counselor. Now, after several months of providing counseling services and working directly with clients, I have gained a much deeper appreciation for the complexity of the profession and the realities of clinical practice.

One of the biggest lessons I have learned is that counseling is rarely as straightforward as it appears in textbooks. Ethical decision-making, treatment planning, and client relationships often involve navigating uncertainty and balancing multiple factors at once. I have found that ethical guidelines provide an important foundation, but professional judgment, consultation, and self-awareness are equally important when working through difficult situations.

Working with clients has also increased my understanding of the emotional demands of the profession. Earlier in my training, I understood the concept of counselor burnout intellectually. Now I recognize how important self-care, boundaries, and supervision truly are. The responsibility of helping individuals through significant emotional struggles can be both rewarding and exhausting. I have learned that maintaining my own well-being is not only beneficial for me but also necessary for providing effective care to clients.

Perhaps the most significant change is that I have become more realistic about my career goals and professional identity. While I entered graduate school with a strong desire to become a counselor, my clinical experiences have led me to question whether this profession is the best long-term fit for me. Although this realization has been difficult, it has also encouraged me to engage in honest self-reflection about my strengths, interests, and future career path. Regardless of where my professional journey ultimately leads, the knowledge, skills, and ethical principles I

have learned through counselor training will continue to influence how I work with and support others.